Class 2: Describing Problems Encountered in Work

Objective: Learn to describe workplace problems and solutions clearly and professionally using appropriate vocabulary and structures.

1. Warm-Up Discussion

- “What kinds of problems do you usually face at work?”
- “Have you ever had a problem with a client, coworker, or system?”
- “Can you describe a time you solved a work problem?”

Model Vocabulary:

- *Problem*: something wrong that needs a solution
- *Challenge*: something difficult that requires effort to overcome
- *Delay*: when something is late
- *Misunderstanding*: when people don’t understand each other correctly

Sample Answer 1 – Logistics Coordinator

Q: What kinds of problems do you usually face at work?

“Sometimes, we have problems with late deliveries from our suppliers. This causes delays in our production schedule.”

Q: Can you describe a challenge you faced at your job?

“One time, our main supplier failed to deliver materials on time. We only had two days to complete a big order.”

Q: How did you solve the challenge?

“I contacted an alternative supplier and arranged for express delivery. We finished the order on time.”

✅ Sample Answer 2 – Customer Service Agent

Q: What problems do you face at work?

“We often deal with complaints from customers about technical issues or delayed responses.”

Q: Can you describe one challenge?

“A customer was very upset because they didn’t receive a reply for two days.”

Q: How did you solve it?

“I apologized, offered a discount, and created a follow-up reminder system. The customer was satisfied in the end.”

✅ Sample Answer 3 – Office Assistant

Q: What kinds of problems do you usually face?

“I sometimes have problems when coworkers don’t reply to important emails.”

Q: Can you describe a challenge you had?

“There was a time when we were planning a meeting, but people didn’t confirm their availability.”

Q: How did you handle it?

“I followed up with a phone call and used an online scheduling tool. Everyone replied quickly after that.”

✅ Sample Answer 4 – IT Support

Q: What problems do you face at work?

“We often face technical issues like slow systems or lost data.”

Q: Can you describe one challenge?

“Our company’s website went offline for three hours during a product launch.”

Q: How did you solve it?

“I worked with our hosting provider to restore the site and posted updates on social media. We resolved the issue and apologized to customers.”

2. Vocabulary & Phrases Introduction

A. Key Vocabulary (with meanings and examples):

Word	Meaning	Example Sentence
Problem	Something that needs a solution	“We had a problem with the system crashing often.”
Challenge	A difficult situation	“The challenge was finishing the work before Friday.”
Issue	A concern or difficulty	“There was an issue with the payment process.”
Difficulty	Something hard to deal with	“We had difficulty understanding the new software.”
Solution	The answer to a problem	“The solution was to retrain the staff.”
Resolve	To fix or deal with a problem	“I resolved the issue by contacting IT support.”
Improve	To make something better	“We improved the process by automating the system.”

Useful Sentence Patterns for IT Contexts

To Present a Problem

Patterns & Vocabulary

1. “We encountered a setback with our deployment pipeline.”
   – *Setback*: a delay or problem that hinders progress.
   – *Example*: “We encountered a setback with our deployment pipeline due to version conflicts.”
2. “A major bottleneck was caused by insufficient server capacity.”
   – *Bottleneck*: a point where progress is slowed or blocked.

– *Example*: “A major bottleneck was caused by insufficient server capacity during peak hours.”

3. “There was a discrepancy in user authentication protocols.”
   – *Discrepancy*: inconsistency or mismatch between expected and actual results.
   – *Example*: “There was a discrepancy in user authentication protocols that led to access issues.”

Check for Understanding

- What is a “bottleneck” in an IT system?
- Give an example of a “setback” in a software project.
- Why is a “discrepancy” in authentication dangerous?

To Explain Actions

Patterns & Vocabulary

1. “I initiated corrective measures by rolling back the faulty update.”
   – *Corrective measures*: actions taken to resolve a problem.
   – *Example*: “I initiated corrective measures by rolling back the faulty update to the last stable version.”
2. “We collaborated with DevOps to optimize the CI/CD workflow.”
   – *Collaborated*: worked jointly on an activity.
   – *CI/CD*: Continuous Integration/Continuous Deployment.
   – *Example*: “We collaborated with DevOps to optimize the CI/CD workflow and reduce downtime.”
3. “A strategic decision was made to migrate to a microservices architecture.”
   – *Strategic decision*: a planned, important choice for improvement.
   – *Microservices*: modular software design.
   – *Example*: “A strategic decision was made to migrate to a microservices architecture for better scalability.”

Check for Understanding

- What are “corrective measures” in IT support?
- Why would a company switch to microservices?
- What is CI/CD and how does it help?

⚙ To Describe the Result

Patterns & Vocabulary

1. “Consequently, system uptime increased by 15%.”
   – *Consequently*: as a result.
   – *System uptime*: percentage of time a system is operational.
   – *Example*: “Consequently, system uptime increased by 15% after we implemented monitoring tools.”

2. “The issue was mitigated after applying a security patch.”
   – *Mitigated*: made less harmful or less severe.
   – *Security patch*: update to fix vulnerabilities.
   – *Example*: “The issue was mitigated after applying a security patch.”
3. “We enhanced system resilience by implementing real-time backups.”
   – *Enhanced*: improved.
   – *System resilience*: ability to recover from failures.
   – *Example*: “We enhanced system resilience by implementing real-time backups.”

Check for Understanding

- What is a “security patch”?
- What does it mean to “mitigate” an issue?
- How can you enhance system resilience?

ANSWERS:

PART 1: Check for Understanding + Answers

1. **Q: What is a “bottleneck” in an IT system?**
   A: A point in the system that slows down performance, like a server with limited processing power.
2. **Q: Give an example of a “setback” in a software project.**
   A: A delay due to a failed system update or a missed delivery deadline.
3. **Q: Why is a “discrepancy” in authentication dangerous?**
   A: It may allow unauthorized access or block legitimate users.

PART 2: Check for Understanding + Answers

1. **Q: What are “corrective measures” in IT support?**
   A: Actions taken to fix technical issues, such as restarting a service or reinstalling software.
2. **Q: Why would a company switch to microservices?**
   A: To improve scalability, reduce downtime, and allow faster deployment of services.
3. **Q: What is CI/CD and how does it help?**
   A: Continuous Integration/Continuous Deployment – it helps automate testing and deployment, making software delivery faster and more reliable.

PART 3: Check for Understanding + Answers

1. **Q: What is a “security patch”?**
   A: A software update designed to fix security vulnerabilities.
2. **Q: What does it mean to “mitigate” an issue?**
   A: To reduce the impact or severity of a problem.
3. **Q: How can you enhance system resilience?**
   A: By adding backups, failovers, load balancing, or redundancy.

3. Practice: Describing a Real Problem

Describe a real problem you faced at work using this structure:

1. “We had a problem with...”
2. “The challenge was...”
3. “I took action by...”
4. “As a result...”

Model Example 1

“We had a problem with customer orders being delayed. The challenge was that the inventory system wasn’t updated in real time. I took action by coordinating with the IT department to fix the sync issues. As a result, the order process became faster and more accurate.”

Model Example 2

“We had a problem with ___. The challenge was ___. I took action by ___. As a result, ___.”

4. Role-Play Activity: Solving a Workplace Problem

Instructions: Describe the situation, explain the issue, and suggest a solution using the vocabulary and structure learned.

Scenario 1: Delay in Project

Problem: The design team is late with their part of the project.
Role-Play Prompt:
“You are informing your manager about the delay. How do you describe the problem and what solution do you suggest?”

Model Response:

“We encountered a delay because the design team missed their deadline. The challenge was coordinating between departments. I took action by scheduling daily check-ins. As a result, the team caught up, and we minimized the delay.”

Scenario 2: Customer Complaint

Problem: A client is unhappy with the service.
Prompt:
“You are speaking to your team leader about how you handled the complaint.”

Model Response:

“There was a problem with slow response times to the customer. The client was frustrated. I apologized and offered a discount. I also created a faster response workflow. As a result, the client was satisfied, and we kept the account.”

Scenario 3: Technical Issue

Problem: The website goes down for two hours.
Prompt:
“How would you explain the problem and the steps you took to resolve it?”

Model Response:

“We had an issue with the server, and the website went offline. I contacted technical support and updated our social media to inform users. As a result, we reduced customer complaints and fixed the site in two hours.”

5. Wrap-Up & Homework

Discussion Questions:

- “What was the most useful phrase you learned today?”
- “Do you feel more confident talking about work problems?”
- “How will you use this vocabulary in your job?”

Optional Homework:

- Task: Write a short email (4–6 sentences) to your manager describing a problem and how you solved it using today’s structure.
- Example:

Subject: Shipping Delay Issue
We had a problem with shipping delays last week. The challenge was that the delivery partner changed their schedule without informing us. I contacted them directly and updated our shipping calendar. As a result, we avoided further delays and informed customers in advance.